

THE HAUNTED HEART

TEXT: Jeremiah 17: 9-10 (NKJV) *“The heart is deceitful above all things, And desperately wicked; Who can know it? ¹⁰ I, the Lord, search the heart, I test the mind, Even to give every man according to his ways, According to the fruit of his doings.”*

INTRO: We have all heard it said, and at some point, been encouraged to *“Follow our heart.”* In other words, we are to follow wherever our feelings lead us. This all sounds good, but on second thought, this may not be the best course of action because the Lord lets us know through the Prophet Jeremiah that *“The heart is deceitful above all things, And desperately wicked.”* In other words; our hearts are susceptible to being haunted by past failures and successes, that may or may not have anything to do with where we should be going in the present.

Yet, many follow their haunted hearts into the horrors of the present and the defeats of the future. (Hell house in Malvern)

I want us to overview the heart this morning, and see why we shouldn't be allowing ourselves to be making decisions based on what our heart is telling us.

THE CHARACTER OF THE HEART

When the Bible talks about the heart being *“deceitful and desperately wicked”* the translation is that it is *“incurably wicked.”* In other words, without the help of the Lord and the work of the Holy Spirit the issue is:

- Terminal...
- Irreversible...
- Without remedy...

You don't have to believe me, listen to what Jesus said about it – Matthew 15:8 *“These people draw nigh unto me with their mouth, and honor me with their lips; but their heart is*

far from me.” Matthew 13:15 “For this people’s heart is waxed gross, and their ears are dull of hearing, and their eyes they have closed; lest at any time they should see with their eyes, and hear with their ears, and should understand with their heart, and should be converted, and I should heal them.”

The character of the heart is:

- Dreadful...
- Deceitful...
- Deranged...
- Distorted...

Sooooo – Don’t follow your heart!

THE CONDUCT OF THE HEART

Paul describes the conduct of the haunted heart like this - Romans 1:28 *“And even as they did not like to retain God in their knowledge, God gave them over to a reprobate mind, to do those things which are not convenient; 29 Being filled with all...”*

- Unrighteousness = Fornication and Wickedness
- Covetousness = Appetite for the things of others
- Maliciousness = Ill will and vengeance
- Envy = This is different than covetousness as it is the spirit that wants not only the things that another person has, but begrudges the fact that the person has them
- Murder = This could be physical murder, but it is more than that – It is also slander – Killing the reputation and influence of another – It is participation in ending the purpose of another
- Debate = A spirit given to fighting!
- Deceit = Lying
- Malignity = A spirit so filled with evil, envy and hatred that it loves nothing better than the destruction of another human being whether it be socially, financially, physically, or any other destructive action

- Whisperers = A gossip who seeks to harm another's reputation
- Backbiters = This is character assassination
- This one is so calloused that it is not done in the shadows, but out in the open
- Haters of God = Hates the standards and restrictions imposed by God - This person becomes the god of their own life – They know better than God how they should live
- Despiteful = A life of defiance that dares God or anyone to get in its way - This kind of person is determined to have his own way at all costs
- Proud = Self exaltation
- Boasters = A person who brags about what he has or what he has done, even if it isn't necessarily true
- Inventors of Evil Things = A person who is tired of sin and seeks new forms of pleasure and excitement
- Disobedient to Parents = Watch a rebellious child! He/she is open to all kinds of sinful

activity, all the while hiding their actions from the parents

- Without Understanding = They have rejected the truth, and have closed their eyes and minds to it
- Covenant Breakers = Untrustworthy - This refers to people who will not keep their word – A signed contract means nothing to this kind of person – A handshake is a joke
- Without Natural Affection = Abnormal affection and love – Fornication – Adultery – Homosexuality – Bestiality - Without affection, emotion or love - A lack of feeling for others - The abuse of normal affection and love
- Implacable = A person who is unwilling to make peace or come to an agreement
- Unmerciful = It is an absence of consideration or feelings for others

The haunted heart is capable of each and every one of these things! Following our hearts doesn't seem like such a good idea now, does it?

THE CONCLUSION OF THE HEART

Matthew 15.19-20, Jesus said: “*Out of the heart* *proceed evil thoughts, murders, adulteries, fornications, thefts, false witness, blasphemies: These are the things which defile a man.*”

Where do these things come from? “*Out of the heart...*”

It was the conclusion of following a haunted heart that tripped up Eve and caused Adam to fall into sin.

It was the conclusion of following a haunted heart that caused David to commit adultery with Bathsheba... And to have her husband Uriah to be put to death!

It was the conclusion of a haunted heart that caused Judas to betray Jesus!

It was the conclusion of a haunted heart that caused Demas to forsake the path of the Gospel to pursue the things of this earth!

Hebrews 3:12-13 ***“Take heed brethren, lest there be in any of you an evil heart of unbelief, in departing from the living God, But exhort one another daily, while it is called Today; lest any of you be hardened through the deceitfulness of sin.”***

- Sin is like fire - It burns and destroys...
- Sin is like rust - It corrodes...
- Sin is like dope - It overwhelms...
- Sin is like poison - It kills...
- Sin degrades, debases, and damns!!!

Proverbs 14:12 ***“There is a way which seems right unto a man, but the end thereof are the ways of death.”*** It seems right to follow our heart but obviously, our heart will lead us to ruin:

- In our conduct...
- In our character...
- In our career...
- In our relationships...
- In our eternity...

James 1:14 ***“But every man is tempted, when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed.***

(Following the haunted heart) ***15 Then when lust hath conceived, it bringeth forth sin: and sin, when it is finished, bringeth forth death.”***

Look at the path the haunted heart takes its followers down:

- Enticement...
- Indulgence...
- Imprisonment...
- Annihilation...

So, what is the alternative to following our haunted hearts? Proverbs 3:5 ***“Trust in the LORD with all your heart; and lean not unto your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct your paths.”***

We are not to follow our haunted heart – We are to ***“Walk in the Spirit so that we will not fulfill the lust of the flesh.”***